

Inequality in a Potential Equalizer of Opportunity

Variation in the Accessibility and Net Benefits of English-Medium Instruction in India

Rishav Roy

WRITING SAMPLE: 10-PAGE COPY

This excerpt contains Introduction and Access to English-Medium Instruction from the full paper. The [full paper](#) and [repository](#) are available online. This writing sample can be generated using `make samples` or `bash scripts/run_full_build.sh`.

Abstract

English-medium instruction (EMI), or the teaching of school subjects in English, is often viewed as a potential palliative for the intergenerational rigidity of socioeconomic status in India, where English skills command substantial wage premia. I study whether the conditions governing households' access to and potential net gains from EMI are themselves unequally distributed. I organize my analysis around three such conditions: inherited linguistic costs of acquiring English, access to English-medium schooling, and the local economic setting in which English skills may be rewarded. By harmonizing district data on languages, schooling, consumption, migration, human capital, and sectoral employment, I find inequality across all three. Inherited linguistic conditions are highly persistent and predict future human capital gains, financial asset access, and structural change, but their relationship with language acquisition behavior varies across institutional settings. EMI exposure and provision are strongly organized by schooling system and sharply stratified along socioeconomic lines, even within the same local education market. Consumption growth is more associated with EMI enrollment than enrollment alone, and the strength of their association increases in pre-existing human capital and urbanization. In sum, a

high-return educational opportunity need not equalize opportunity when access to it and the resources required to benefit from it are themselves unequal.